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Doug Carn

Keyboardist and composer Doug Carn's recording career began in 1969 and he has produced iconic recordings for the Black Jazz record label. Doug has collaborated with vocalist Jean Carn, and with drummer Cindy Blackman, and trumpeter Wallace Roney.

Doug was interviewed via Zoom on February 24, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Doug Carn with me this afternoon, from Florida. Congratulations on your career so far.

DC: Well thank you.

MR: I'm wondering when you were young, let's say your teen years around 15, had you already chosen music as your career or as what you wanted to pursue or did you have other choices?

DC: I had another choice but I'd already chosen music a long time ago, when I was about 8 years old. But I got a full scholarship in '63 to the US Air Force Academy out in Colorado and I was going to try, I was going to be an astronaut I guess but they gave me a full scholarship but I turned it down I said no, I'm going to play music.

MR: So you had been around 15 years old then?

DC: Yeah.

MR: Did your mother, who was a music teacher, did she agree with that choice?

DC: Of course. You know she almost named me Jerome, that way I would have been Jerome Carn like Jerome Kern you know.

MR: Oh yes.

DC: She did philharmonic rehearsals while I was still in the womb, you know, which she is going to do all that, you know. She had a German music teacher that teached me piano lessons and stuff and then launched my ass in space playing piano. And another thing a lot of people don't realize, see when you come up in the black church, especially a prominent black church, to play on special events, even on Sundays to between 500 and a thousand people and get applause and smiles and coodles, that's a big deal. This is a big deal now. Most major clubs in the world only have — seat two or three hundred people you know. And so it wasn't no big deal for me going before an audience with 200 people, 250 people, like going in the basement at the Vanguard you know I was not intimidated like that.

MR: You had already played to some big crowds.

DC: Yeah, right.

MR: Is that where you got your first organ experience? In the church?

DC: Yes. Played a real church organ. Then we got a Hammond, but mother majored in music and church music you know. She was back there with Mrs. Madam Willa Dobbs and them sisters, it was Rebecca Steel and all of them heavyweights. And these average organ players, they don't know what a [inaudible] is. They're really not organ players. They're not piano players either. They're somebody with keyboard skills and they want to get the organ sound so they, you know, got a keyboard and learned how to play left hand bass. But they're not no organ players.

MR: Yeah, I was just going to ask about left hand bass because that's a passion of mine. And I was watching you on a video that someone did in their home. And you were really wailing on the B3 and you were doing the left hand bass. And it's a powerful feeling because you can really control the music. You're the bass player and the soloist, and the chordal person.

DC: No different from Johann Sebastian Bach. I keep trying to tell these idiots you've got to build on cumulative knowledge you know, and you can't reinvent the wheel yourself.

MR: Do you think differently or play different — well I'm going to say do you think differently when you have a bass player?

DC: Well yes. Yes you do.

MR: How so?

DC: Well it's just like being a pianist, you play different from when you play solo piano than when you play with the orchestra you know. You think differently. But you play the same, but you think different. They say you have more freedom with a bass player but you're in a wider arena anyway, so thinking different is par for the course. It's a negative sum game. You know?

MR: Yeah. I understand you were in a group called the New Tones when you were in school?

DC: That was a group I had in junior high and high school because you know you had to make money. You needed money in your pocket as a young man, and that was just what I kind of naturally did, so I put a band together. We got some uniforms and started playing shows, you know, proms and socials, in the immediate area in the region you know.

MR: Can you name a few tunes that would have been on your songlist?

DC: Well yes, some of them were straight jazz you know. Like we played "Misty," we played "Red Top," we played "Blue Moon," we played "How High the Moon," we played "The Work Song," we played a couple of Horace Silver's that was out in the late 50s. Then we played "Twist and Shout," the Isley Brothers. We played a little Wilson Pickett, "Midnight Hour," a little Otis Redding. You know we played what the people wanted to hear.

MR: I understand that group, if I'm correct, auditioned to be on the Ted Mack Amateur Hour?

DC: Yeah, we did. That was the day that Kennedy got killed, man. We were on the way to Jacksonville and they said our version of "Blue Moon" it was too jazzy. But nobody was in a good mood but it went too jazzy, our "Blue Moon" was going to be too jazzy. Now if I'd played it like Ornette Coleman might have played it, yeah, you could say that, but it was danceable you know. But nobody was in a good mood but I don't think they was going to give it to nobody black during that time you know, in Jacksonville, Florida. But we — on our way to Jacksonville it seems like we heard it on the radio so we stopped at the first gas station and a lot of people were stopped and they had a television in there and we went in there and the owners gave us orange juice you know, and that was a place that didn't serve black people, but everybody was acting like a human being on that day I guess, except the people that was happy that Kennedy got shot, but they didn't come in there you know. Then we had to leave to be there on time for the audition and they didn't like it you know.

MR: It was a little too out for them I suppose, at the time.

DC: Yeah.

MR: What do you remember from your years — you mentioned that they weren't ready for a black group. Did you experience, during your early music careers with being segregated from certain parts of your town or society?

DC: Well there were a couple of incidents, but nothing that would break the spirit you know. I'll tell you once we played at the YMCA downtown you know, so we was the first black band quote unquote to play at the white YMCA. And I think this was '61 you know. And so — maybe '62. So we played at the white YMCA so I'm playing white records you know, and the main thing was the Beatles, because the Beatles were the hot new thing you know. And some of the Beatles things I really liked you know. But by the time of Sgt. Pepper's — you could say I was a Beatles fan but I liked some of the stuff they was doing. But the kids didn't dance to any of it except when we played "Twist & Shout" and I was thinking that that was an Isley Brothers song you know — who was a black group — so they danced to that. So during the break we went in a little room they had for us with Coca Colas and fruit and sandwiches and stuff. So the director and a couple of the students came back there and the director said, "Doug, your band is very good and professional and it sounds real good, but do you think when you go back you could play some of your people's music?" So the girl said, "James Brown." And the boy said, "Otis Redding." You know. And they started calling all these black group names. So I figured out what it was they wanted you know. So the director says, "Look, Doug, I could lose my job you know — I'm going out on a limb bringing a black group here and y'all are playing the God damn Beatles? Now you go back out there and play some of your music,

your stuff, like you know you're supposed to do." So we went out there and did [sings] You know you make me want to shout/shout. Oh they loved that.

MR: That's a great story. Do you suppose the white kids were hearing most of that from the radio stations or were they actually buying the records?

DC: They listened to the high end of the radio stations. I figured they listened to their end you know? I even figured they listened to that stuff, but they listened to that more than they listened — now I knew who Ferlin Husky was. I knew who the Big Bopper was. I certainly knew who Ricky Nelson was, you know, and I knew who Tammy Wynette was. You know I knew these people, some of them, and, but they knew all our people. They were big fans of Sam Cooke you know. And so I never did figure that I was playing for white folks. I thought I was playing for upwardly progressive black people you know. And even when they got to be real serious deep jazz it was kind of the same thing you know, in the big cities and up north there was more black people into it per se. A great deal of the fans were white you know. And you know I found that really interesting you know, even to this day. It's like that whole new generation, actually a third generation, in my case the white kids were into real jazz you know. So it was quite weighty and substantial in its substance, in essence you know.

MR: Wonderful. The music that you were playing at that time at some point did you decide instead of going down this pop music road I have something I want to say in the jazz world?

DC: Right because this is the thing, I had said all of that through high school, like "It's Just the Nearness of You" you know. But the substance of the song and the lyrics is the same as some of these R&B songs. Baby let me get close to you, you know? I mean and it's romantic you know. It's just on a higher level. But the problem was I wanted to play you know. I just didn't want to play songs you know. So I said well maybe I'll write some songs the way that I would like to play them you know, the type that I would like to play. And my mom had a bunch of books, poetry books by Yeats and Keats and different people. And you know I've read those you know. All she would do is leave a book laying around and I would open it up like it was a piece of candy because I was kind of motivated by the way they tricked me into reading encyclopedias you know. They told me that all of mankind's accumulated knowledge was in these books you know, and I believed it. It took me about a year to do it, and I didn't say nothing you know. I just read it slowly and I found out there were many things that my parents being school teachers did not know you know. They didn't know how air conditioning worked you know. So many things they didn't know. But you know I wrote my own lyrics because I wanted to push the music forward because even when I came along you know with "Misty" and

"How High the Moon" and all of them songs was old tunes then. You know? "Satin Doll" was an old song in 1962 you know?

MR: Yeah that's very interesting how we have different definitions of old.

DC: Right. They say, "Man that music is old." I said, "Man that music ain't old. You think that's old, what about Shostakovich Tenth Symphony? What about you know a German leider, you know, and Mozart? That's old. What about Gregorian chant? That's old. Brahms, he was an old man, he used to hang around the college they knew Brahms you know? Ravel was still alive before World War I you know. So that ain't old you know and now they call it Earth, Wind & Fire old school you know. They're the most wanted popular band that ever existed — but old. The stuff they're doing now as a backdrop to hip hop, you know, it's barely music.

MR: It's barely music because why?

DC: Because they took music out of the curriculum of the public school system you know. And the children don't know any music. They don't know music. It's a miracle that they have accomplished what they have accomplished now, for the black churches you know to be totally null and void.

MR: When I read about your music from the 70s especially, whoever is writing it, I don't know if it's you or over the years management, they mention spiritual jazz, spiritual music. And I'd like to know if that's the way you thought of it yourself. Did you think of it as spiritual and was that part of your direction?

DC: Well that was the trend going then you know. Because the Civil Rights Movement was in full swing you know. And there was Martin Luther King, Reverend Doctor Martin Luther King. He was a preacher. That's spiritual you know. Muhammad Ali you know, he had Kareem Abdul-Jabbar, that was spiritual you know, and then we had what else did we have, Coltrane.

MR: Coltrane.

DC: He was a cat, and Miles was very deep and spiritual. He didn't use spiritual titles but his music was almost sacred you know, some of it, a great deal of it you know. And but the thing is I just want to interject while I'm thinking so I won't forget, you know the way these interviews and conversations go it seems like the whole world revolves around black/white issues you know but they don't you know. There's a lot of Asian people that play good classical music and jazz you know, but that's what we talk about in terms of black/white issues because the conflict and tension centers around that.

MR: How do you think that conflict — is it different now?

DC: No.

MR: Than it was in the 70s?

DC: No. It ain't no different. You know a white man and black man playing 7-Up. The black wins the money but scared to pick it up. No it ain't no different you know the musicians do all the work and all the creativity, mostly black, and the white folks do the management and set the agendas and all of that, and do the recording, and all the company controls the distribution and they make all the money. Now they give you a lot of money if you sell completely out and play something that compliments a way of life that's more conducive to the status quo than to black enlightenment. You know they'll give you money. They don't care about the money. The only thing they care about is saying that you are equal to them, which they don't want to do. But getting back on track to where we was coming from, so I wrote these lyrics and it was down with the times you know. It just happened to be that time. See the songs I did, "Little B's Poem," "Infant Eyes," "A Love Supreme," "Peace," and "Passion Dance," and one of my originals, all those songs had been played before you know. But they had been played in a group setting that showed that much consideration and thought you know, and it was during the black power movement so I put on a dashiki and took the picture you know. But I could have played that same music in a three-piece suit and a necktie.

MR: Good point.

DC: It would have had a different tone. But "Little B's Poem"; Bobby Hutcherson, he had played that. And I'll tell you Bobby Hutcherson ended up having to play my arrangement of "Little B's Poem." As it worked out you know that intro [scats] because he had played many shows and people would ask him, "Hey, did you write 'Little B's Poem?'" And he said, "Yeah I wrote it." He says, "Play that." So he started going [scats]. He said, "No that ain't how it goes" [scats] so they started playing. They went and got Joey DeFrancesca to play it on organ, because it was the organ that made it sound like that you know. But it wasn't that, it was the way that me and Michael Carvin interpreted it you know. Because see it's in 3/4 time so it's easy to interpret it as a waltz you know [scats]. But we interpreted it as [scats]. One-two-three, one-two-three, one-two-three, one-two-three, one-two-three-four, one-two-three-four.

MR: I see. Yeah I just watched him play it with Cedar Walton on a video the other day.

DC: Yeah. And so you know I put a lot of thought in it you know, and to tell people you spent a great deal of your time thinking. They can't get to that you know. You know they can't get to that. He's supposed to be spending a great deal of your time putting stress on your back and lifting weights you know.

MR: The people that were recording a great deal in the mid-70s, there was a lot of heavy duty fusion with Herbie Hancock and Mahavishnu, Weather Report.

DC: Well see Miles always led the way. See he got tired of playing the same thing anyway. Everywhere he'd go they said, "Play 'My Funny Valentine'" you know. He didn't want

to play that no more. And Miles was very fashion oriented you know and the styles were changing you know. And for what it's worth the music was changing too you know? So he said "In a Silent Way," I'm going to change. He knew what the barometer was, you know? Because I'll tell you, I took "Bitches Brew" as a joke you know almost. You know? We put on "Bitches Brew" and rolled a big fat joint and put the color wheel on and strobe light on, and go for a ride. But when I actually played the music with Wallace Roney, I could see the dimensions in it you know, just like classical music [scats]. You know. [scats]. You know what I mean? And so I said, "Wait a minute." And so much of it sounded like "Sketches of Spain" you know. And for all that change, Miles actually played the same way you know. If you listen to what Miles is actually playing. But yeah, man, you've got to — the only thing inevitable is change. And change is the last thing you want to do. But after a while you've got to change, you know. You've got to adapt you know.

MR: Yeah he was always ahead of the curve and I'm always fascinated that he was able to fashion the music to his own strengths and weaknesses in his playing.

DC: What weakness?

MR: Touche!

DC: I know what you're saying.

MR: You got me.

DC: I know what you're saying. Yeah. But Miles was advantaged because he was rich you know. He was born rich so he wasn't under pressure, you know, so he could be creative the way he could. But he didn't smile but he was really a down to earth brother you know, a real cat you know.

MR: Well that's a good point. I wonder, the music that you created of your own, did it have something to do with what your economic situation was like?

DC: No. No. No. It had nothing to do with that, it was just cultural you know. But see the thing is, see a lot of these musicians and athletes and other people too, they grew up, they get rich because they grew up poor you know. Now I didn't grow up poor but I probably wasn't far from it, especially based on today's standards you know, but see if you grew up in a family with parents that love you and care for you and you live in a decent house, eat good food and you wear nice clothes and you drive a nice car, it might not be a Cadillac, but it's usually brand new or almost brand new, you eat good food, you know, and you've got a hustle on the side. We did a lot of fishing. And then I had the band. But even when I was a kid, 8, 9 years old, I would sell soda water bottles to get a deposit you know. I kept me some change in my pocket. And then how are you going to have a four point average and be poor you know? That's the last thing I was complaining about, that we didn't have enough money. But I didn't want a pony, you know, I didn't want a horse.

But I guess if I had wanted one they would have bought me one to just stay in the stable and I could go there and ride him, but they couldn't buy me an airplane I'm sure but I could take lessons you know, and learn how to fly you know.

MR: I wanted to ask you, before I forget, did you think it was really hip that your mother played with Dizzy Gillespie a couple of times?

DC: Extremely hip. And she didn't tell me that until I got older you know. I was probably about 40 when she told me that. But what had happened was she was in Harlem. She'd go up to Harlem during the summer and stay with Uncle T which was my grand-uncle, my grandmama's brother, and work you know. But she would also go up there to go to Juilliard which I didn't know. But she got into a summer program where she'd go to Juilliard and rehearse you know. Yeah, she had a friend from a talent show at the Apollo and so mama played for her and the girl won. And Dizzy was one of the judges. And so Dizzy paid her a compliment and invited her to a gig of his, I think it was at the Harlem YMCA. But anyway she went and the piano player didn't show so the guy was acting like he didn't want to pay Diz because he didn't have a band. And so they said, "There's a piano player right there, come on, baby." So my mama made the gig. Then she played another one, then he called her again and she wouldn't go 'cause I was sick you know. So he didn't call her no more after that.

MR: I like that term, "My mama made the gig."

DC: Yeah.

MR: That's terrific.

DC: And then she was gigging anyway. As a matter of fact my first gig was with the band she was with before I started the New Tones you know. Because she could read music so if they wanted to play "All the Things You Are" or "Stella by Starlight," she would play it correctly and she knew that she played it, and the chords over and over again, the same structure. But they kept being after her about soloing you know. And she didn't want to solo. She didn't want to improvise. She didn't want to play something and not know what she was playing. She was that kind of musician you know, that I'm not playing nothing that I don't know what I'm playing, that was her point of view you know.

MR: How did that work for you? Did you stumble into improvising because it was required or did you really seek it out beforehand?

DC: The one and the same. It was part of it you know. As a matter of fact, I didn't know it was improvising, like with "Bags' Groove" like when Miles said [scats] you know? I didn't know that was necessarily improvised. As a matter of fact, I hadn't really seen a lead sheet until after I had read "Infant Eyes" you know. You know it was just playing and then after a while you realized they was soloing. Because see most people, they don't improvise off the song anyway. They improvise off the chord changes. For instance like

he said, “Well let’s play ‘Straight, No Chaser.’” You say okay. Well “Straight, No Chaser” is a blues you know. So you play “Straight, No Chaser” and when the solos start, you know, they might as well be playing “Every Day I Have the Blues” or anything you know, but they’re not improvising off “Straight, No Chaser” because see if you was improvising off “Straight, No Chaser” you’d say [scats] you know like the melody [scats]. You know what I mean?

MR: Yeah like you almost turned it upside down.

DC: Yeah you improvise off the melody and the chords, but they just improvise off the chords. This is why they could steal each other’s music with the same chord changes. Like take “Indiana” and make it “Donna Lee.” You understand what I’m saying?

MR: I do. Yeah.

DC: But so I said, “Man, you know something? Y’all don’t know nothing about music” you know. They said, “Who do you think you are, a little Negro from St. Augustine, Florida you know. You don’t know diddly.” I said, “I might not but I know about music. You all don’t know nothing about music” you know then I bowed my head and backed off you know. But you know that’s the thing, you know so, but then yeah, I realized you improvised but actually Gary Bartz taught me this, you’re not really improvising, you’re a composer you know. It’s just quick work. Just like spontaneous artwork you know, when they’re painting a picture, just painting it fast, but it’s like [scats] you know? You’re not really — you know you’re creating, you’re actually writing music. And that’s another beef that I got with the industry. You know you do a song and the soloist don’t get paid for what they’re doing. They say, “Brubeck wrote it — Green wrote the tune, Coleman Hawkins just played it.” But see when you buy a jazz record you buy the record to hear what solos the guys took you know? Not just two chords inside the melody. You know what I’m saying?

MR: Right. You’re not getting any writer’s credit for the improvising.

DC: Right. So they’d do “Take Five” all right? And in that solo that Joe Morello took, he don’t get no money for that. You know what I’m saying?

MR: I do.

DC: Those 52 choruses of “Crescendo and Diminuendo” that Paul Gonzalves played, he don’t get no money for that, you know what I mean? And all the great solos with all that stuff, Trane played on “My Favorite Things,” You know Rodgers, Hammerstein get all of that money you know, as if they wrote it. You know? And but see where it came from was way back in the day before “Bye-Bye Blackbird” and them other songs, and “Tiger Rag” and stuff. You know you’d play the record and then the little stuff you did in between like an ad lib wasn’t that considerable even though it was they just let that go and passed that on, but you’re still playing Irving Berlin’s song you know. But after the swing era came

in, and especially bebop, they started adding more music to the composition than the composition had in the first place. You know what I'm saying?

MR: I do.

DC: And so but they don't get paid for that. You know? See actually I'm not being bitter or have an attitude about it, but record companies owe the jazz musicians half of all the money they made, the publishing companies too you know. Because they copyrighted and collected money through performance rights organizations of music that they did not create you know. If they was only going to get paid for owning the melody then you don't need other stars to play you know? Just get a drum machine to keep the beat and let Oscar Peterson play you know? And then but they've got to have George Duvivier or Ray Brown to fill in in the rhythm section making the sound groovy you know. And the publisher would get more money than Oscar Peterson, he'd get double or triple if you're smart as Ray Charles you'd get ten times as much as a sideman or whatever. But there's so many holes in it. This is why a lot of educated people wouldn't be a musician, wouldn't be in the music business. Because they have studied it thoroughly you know, and it's always for somebody that's got ego enough, you know, to want to be up there on the stage with people clapping for them and girls swooning you know. But to some of us there's a duty too, you know, because we realize that the people need culture, and music and culture and dance is for the betterment of society and the well being of the people.

MR: A couple of years ago someone wrote a nice article about you, a fellow named Aaron Cohen, "Doug Carn's Big Moment." And there's a quote from you in it. It said, "My plan is you better get out of the way because I'm tired of holding back." And I wonder if at various times in your career did you feel that you were held back from what you really wanted to do?

DC: Yeah. I feel like that right now, because they got it as entertainment only. You know? Because if you look at that, those trees that they have with the roots of jazz you know, down at the bottom they got Satchmo and Bix Beiderbecke, and then they got, you know, the different people you know. And they come on up with Barney Bigard and —

MR: Jelly Roll Morton and those people.

DC: Yes and all those people and they come on up then they get the bebop days you know, pre-bebop you know. But I'm telling you, Nat King Cole, Sammy Davis Junior, Miles Davis, even Sinatra, Tony Bennett, but we're focusing on the black ones and, you know, Dexter Gordon and Doug Carn and all the rest, we're on that same tree we're just another jigaboo we're just a higher level of fruit of the same tree is the way they look at it, you know? And that you know so at any given night they say, "[inaudible] What are we going to open up?" You know, "I said well I don't know, I said let's do some 'All the Things You Are?'" You know 180 miles away in Vegas Sammy'd say, "Well why don't we open

up with 'All the Things You Are" now. And in New York Dexter Gordon kicks it off you know, they're all playing the same tune, drinking the same whiskey, you know, eating the same steaks, you know, competing for the same dollar you know. And they say, "Yeah, man, but them guys in a big band in Vegas, Reno and Tahoe, they can't play like the cats can." I said, "The hell they can't" you know. You don't know what you're talking about. Sal Nistico and Curtis Peagler and them boys you know, I can't think because I'll leave it, the guy's name — you know but them guys can play you know. I didn't know that Al Cohn played so well you know, so modern sounding. Because I've been seeing his name a long time, since I was in high school you know. And then I said, "That's Al Cohn?" You know because he could play like Dexter Gordon you know. And I said, Man, them guys could play, they just rather make the money and live in a house, and send their kids to college you know, because a lot of the people I understand, but now don't get me wrong, they called it the "Chitlin Circuit." It was a very nutritious chitlin, you know, they'd send their sons and daughters to college and buy cars and houses you know. See some people ain't good with money anyway you know, but it's all the same thing but you've got to worry about the people that love them, or you don't you know, and sometimes you wonder if it's worth it you know.

MR: Do you think you made decisions along your career that cost you money but you stuck with your artistic vision?

DC: Yeah. I hate to see those interviews, they say well look, just tell me if you had to do it all over again would you do the same thing? They said well yeah, really you know, I'd do the same thing. But I wouldn't. You know? If I know what I know now, I wouldn't do the same thing you know. But they don't want to admit that they weren't perfect, or they still want to imagine that life was idealized for them. No if I had to do the same thing over again I wouldn't do it the same way. Hell no.

MR: I'm always surprised when I learn about musicians that I listened to and read about when — growing up, and in some cases I got to meet them and to find out that they would play gigs that I would never imagine. That they would play weddings, you know, because everybody's got to make a buck.

DC: Right. And then too, I'm going to tell you all this truth, man — it's nothing wrong with playing a wedding. I played a wedding in 2012 with the same band I had in Dizzy's Coca Cola, because the guy was a friend of mine and he was a fan of mine and he loved jazz you know, and he wanted a real jazz group at his daughter's wedding. You know? So we played it you know? But what's wrong with playing a miscellaneous wedding for miscellaneous people for miscellaneous money on a miscellaneous circumstance. But a good wedding like Oscar Peterson played for Prince Charles' and Diana's wedding, or the reception. I would have played that gig in a minute. You know I played for weddings,

I played for a funeral, I played for a birthday party, but the real deal, not no jive, this poverty-stricken, you know, and academically deplete you know, depleted or whatever you know.

MR: Sometimes — I think the public, I think the public is fascinated sometimes with the struggle of musicians and they think it's a royal thing to do to stick to your musical vision and live in poverty for it.

DC: Yeah. Well that's the western point of view anyway. That's one of the things I don't like about some people interpreting Christianity. They thing you're supposed to suffer you know. You ain't supposed to suffer, you know, and a lot of times they won't get you a good hotel room or get you good food, because the harder it is, you know, to be out there, the better you play. I say I'll play better when I get a limo then a suite you know, in a five-star building.

MR: Well said. Am I correct that you adopted the Muslim religion at some point?

DC: Yeah, a long time ago.

MR: Was there something in society that was happening at the time or —

DC: I'll tell you right now before you ask me —

MR: Okay.

DC: What it is, it was the idea, the clarity of the oneness of God you know. To me God is singular you know. And I had no partners, and Christianity — well Judaism is that way. They, you know, it's just God that's it. But Christianity got three Gods. Now they say it's one God but in three parts you know. And then the one part is his son, one part is the holy spirit. But I don't think the almighty God would need a son you know. What do you need a son for you're almighty and merciful. The almighty, he's perfectly capable of being a savior, for showing mercy he made the sun and the moon and the stars and everything else. He's perfectly capable of redeeming you if you need redemption you know. So you know that said but I found that the good aspects of most religions you know, in Hinduism they've got a trinity too, but then they've got many other gods. But it's not a Catch-22 word but it's a loaded word you know, because whatever the name of the diety is that's on most high, it wouldn't be in English or any language of human beings anyway because you know God is above a human being, way above it. I think there was Mohammed, peace be upon him, that asked somebody — they was out one night and he said, "Hey, man." He says, "Yeah, what?" He said, "You see all that out there?" He said, "Yeah." He said, "What do you think is easier to make, to make that or to make you?" You know? And he had to say, "To make me" you know. Rather than make all that you know. And he didn't have the slightest clue how much that was, how full it was, how huge it was you know, but see we have to use first person singular. That's why we say him or his you know. And that's what we call a big ship a she or her you know, because it's greater than

the average human being but it ain't greater, it's far, far away from it you know, the way I look at it. And when he says well he made man in his own image I say, "Yeah man got an image of his own" so you know he made man in his own image, not in his image, not in my image. I don't have no image you know. If I had an image how could you compose it in a human being? You mean to tell me the guy that made Venus, whoever made Venus, Pluto, Neptune, Mars, and Andromeda, the galaxy, has got two hands and two eyes and a tongue and eat and use the bathroom you know? What is he, a million miles tall you know? You know that's crazy. And if he's like a man and has got a son, he don't have no wife, they say well no, he don't need no wife, he can just have a son you know, or do what he wants. I said yeah, you don't need a son either, but it gets to be like that because of our language. But Judaism is closes to it. You know it's the same thing actually because Ishmael and who's the other one — the brothers of Abraham and his two sons.

MR: In the Old Testament you mean?

DC: Yeah. When Sara sent the handmaid away with the boy, the two boys got separated so their language changed you know. So the one who was with Abraham — was it Isaac?

MR: I can't say.

DC: But anyway he would say, "Shalom [inaudible] and then Ishmael said, "Shalom Le Chiem" you know. The language got compromised you know, on both sides. But it's really the same. Migrants, you know, the Arabic-speaking [inaudible] and the Jewish one was saying [inaudible]. I don't want to get in an argument about that. That's why I don't stretch it, but to me if there is a God there can be no comparisons whatsoever. When they say we'll reach out and touch the face of God — that's symbolic you know. You know that's an analogy. That's a metaphor you know. God don't have no face but he got a beard too? He got teeth you know? He got 20/20 vision, 360 degree vision but both his eyes face forward you know? They're thinking about Zeus and Atlas you know and [inaudible] and people like that and personas like that.

MR: Well thanks for sharing that. I'd like to — before we're done here I want to just ask you about the last few years. It's been interesting because some of your music from the 70s has been revisited and now they're calling it classic, and at the same time you got hooked up with the two fellas from the Jazz Is Dead label and I just find it an interesting pairing.

DC: Well that's the biggest trick that's been played on me in my life. They said, "Look, man, we've got some hip-hop tracks and we want to dub you on a couple of them. Gary Bartz is going to do some and Roy Ayers is going to do some." I said, "Okay, how much you going to pay me?" So we agreed on a price but they didn't say the name on the label is going to be Jazz Is Dead, and be promoting a concept named Jazz Is Dead. They didn't' say nothing about that. I didn't know nothing about that until it came out. And when I say

"tricked me" I don't mean a dirty stab in the back trick you know, they just didn't say nothing about it you know. And that didn't rattle me too much you know, but we played a gig and we'd go in the auditorium and all these Jazz Is Dead posters was all over the walls and it was kind of discouraging you know, but they're intelligent young men, they're clean cut and I give them a break. But I tell any young people, older people too, if you're going to tear something down and destroy it, make sure you've got something to replace it with.

MR: Good point. It's interesting that they didn't tell you about that because it seems like it was a calculated move.

DC: It was calculated, and a lot of my jazz fans, it hurt them you know, and they thought that I had sold out you know. I said, "Well if I sold out, I sold out for free because I ain't got no money." You know? But they've been saying jazz is dead a long time you know, just like they say God is dead you know, ever since fusion came in you know.

MR: Yeah every couple of years you see it in the jazz magazines and I think it's just like okay it's time to write about that again, because it's just something to write about.

DC: Right. Because in the 70s the fusion started, they were saying jazz is dead. But then here comes Wynton Marsalis you know, playing more jazz than anybody ever played you know, and all these young people and jazz programs in colleges and universities. You know that's the thing about America and a free society. It's free speech you know, and people can say what they want to say, can believe what they want to be and you can't get bent out of shape. You know if jazz is dead then classical music has got to be dead a long time. But Beethoven, Bach and Brahms, they're just as big as they ever were you know. Especially in Europe.

MR: Do you think that jazz education sort of the explosion of it in the last twenty years has been a good thing for the music?

DC: Well in a way, see the music is very broad and there have been aspects to it you know. And one aspect that's been making it accessible to musicians who ordinarily wouldn't access it you know. And on the other hand it's big in that kind of mundane and dry to people who loved it enough to run away from home and move to New York and sleep on the floor in an apartment in the Village and hang out until two or three in the morning and follow Kenny Garrett around, you know, and follow Mike Brecker around you know, follow you know —

MR: Who did you follow around?

DC: Jimmy Smith. I followed all the organ players, every last one of them. Groove Holmes, Jimmy Smith, McDuff, Doctor Lonnie Smith, Shirley Scott. My uncle was good friends with Shirley and Stan and you know Trudy Pitts, Jimmy McGriff, I followed every one of them. You know I knew how they set up the organ, what kind of tunes they played using

the organ. You know some of them didn't know what kind they was using themselves. But I followed all the organ players.

MR: Well I want to thank you for your time and I want to re-visit — we had had a start to this interview that we had to re-do and I had mentioned the — "Sometimes I Feel Like a Motherless Child" from your very first record.

DC: Yeah Joey DeFrancesca recorded that one too. I was sad that he had to pass away so early.

MR: Yes. Well it's a beautiful recording and it sounded like, you know, like you were in church.

DC: Well the organ is a church instrument. You know that's why black people love it so much, you know, certain black people. Certain black people don't like organ or didn't like it because they felt that it kept them in that old school church blues idiom and they wanted to go forward you know. I said, "Well you ever heard Larry Young Junior?" They said, "Oh yeah I heard that noise and all that wild stuff." I said, "Yeah but it's stuff like 'Unity' and that is "Zoltan," that other ones that he did too." You know they tried to hold you to one bag when you play jazz you know, but they didn't hold Van Cliburn in one bag playing classical music. He can play a Rachmaninoff or Debussy you know. Because that's Van Cliburn. But if you go outside the established perimeters that they've got for you then you've either sold out or changed you know. They want to see you play until you die on the stage you know. You know 'til you're in a wheelchair and ragged and can hardly play you know. And I remember I was in Kansas City and was it Jay McShann was playing — was it Jay McShann that Bird used to play with?

MR: Yes that's correct.

DC: I was five years old and he was playing and I'm there, not on the dais but in the broader distinguished people for what it was and I looked him tiptoeing out to the piano smiling, you know balancing on air with his two hands. So I told the boy sitting next to me, I said, "Man when I get so old that I can't hardly walk and hold my water and stuff, I ain't going to keep playing and I'm going to quit. I'm going to retire you know. I ain't going to play no more. And there was another old man, he had to be about 90 himself, he said, "If they give you fifty thousand dollars you will."

MR: Oh that's a good way to wrap up, and I'm going to look for fifty grand to send your way.

DC: The grandchildren need it. I've got three great grands man.

MR: Awesome.

DC: And I can't go and see them, they're going to have to come and see me you know. Every now and then I get under the weather. I'm under the weather now you know. But I can play you know. But I don't want to be having to creep to the piano then get carried away from the piano on a stretcher you know. You know I'll play for a while or if anything I

will get a protégé and get him to play and sit on the sidelines and coach him along you know, and root for him you know. It's just like being a football coach or a boxing coach or a golf coach you know, you can't really play good no more, but you've got knowledge so you can participate in some way. But when you get so old they're not getting out — they used to get out there and try to quarterback you know.

MR: Yeah. Well you've shared a lot of knowledge with me today, Mr. Carn, and I really appreciate it.

DC: All right.

MR: Thank you for your time.

DC: Okay. Thank you.